

Knights in combat
The knights of Edward III of England and Philip VI of France do battle at Crécy, in northern France, in August 1346 *(above)*, one of the first major clashes of the Hundred Years' War. A knight was always well equipped when on campaign; he took with him a minimum of two mounts and a squire, and was heavily laden with armour and weapons. The basinet helmet *(right)* has a distinctive pointed visor (nicknamed a "hounskull").

THE EUROPEAN KNIGHT was a formidable warrior, an armoured horseman equipped with lance and sword who – in principle if not always in practice – dominated the medieval battlefield with his superior fighting skills. The knight also represented a cultural ideal of Christian manhood whose honour, valour, and virtue were celebrated in the epic poetry of the period. In practice, as professional fighting men, knights were of necessity immersed in the inglorious reality of medieval warfare, besmirched by countless episodes of plunder and massacre.

The medieval knight emerges obscurely into the pages of history from the heavy cavalry employed in the realms of the great Frankish ruler Charlemagne and his successors in the 9th and 10th centuries. These were mounted fighting men with a key role in warfare but no special status or prestige, serving a local lord or the king. From around the middle of the 11th century, however, knights began to be recognized as elite warriors of notable social standing. The crusader movement against Muslim control of the Holy Land highlighted the image of knights as specifically Christian warriors and defenders of the Church. Knights' prestige rose so rapidly that, by the 12th century, every nobleman was happy to describe himself as a knight, although most knights were not noblemen.

BECOMING A KNIGHT

The special status of knights was confirmed by public ceremonies and symbols, as well as being protected by laws and decrees that attempted to guarantee its exclusivity. Heraldic emblems, used to decorate banners, shields, and surcoats so that helmeted knights could be readily identified at tournaments or in battle, developed into a system of symbols identifying each warrior's place in the knightly caste. Over time the lowborn were explicitly forbidden from becoming knights and knightly status became largely hereditary. Boys of appropriate social standing would serve first as pages and then as squires in the household of a knight who ensured their education in horsemanship and the use of the sword and lance. When they were old enough and were judged fit to be knights, knighthood was formally conferred with the ceremony of the "accolade", a girding with a sword or touch of sword or hand on the shoulder. In the case of a royal prince or the son of a nobleman this would be the occasion for elaborate festivities.

COSTLY ROLE

Kings increasingly assumed the exclusive right to confer knighthoods and used this as a means of raising revenue, charging a hefty fee for the privilege. By the 14th century, many qualified by birth to be knights tried to avoid the expense and onerous duties it involved. As well as the cost of the accolade, there was a substantial outlay for equipment and mounts. A knight needed at least two horses when on campaign – a palfrey, or saddle horse, for ordinary travel and a splendid destrier, or warhorse, for combat. Full plate armour, which gradually replaced the mix of chainmail and plate, was very expensive, shaped to offer protection against missiles and sword blows, yet light and well balanced enough to be comfortable when fighting on foot. The knight would also need a lance, a sword, a shield, and probably a mace, war-hammer, or poleaxe.

Many young men with military ambitions were prepared to pay for the horses and kit but baulked at the cost of a knighthood, or lacked the requisite birth qualification. They remained squires or sergeants, fighting alongside the knights and largely indistinguishable from them on the battlefield. A squire or sergeant might hope to receive an accolade on the battlefield in recognition of some spectacular feat of arms, though such on-the-spot knightings were not common. Knights, squires, and sergeants were collectively known as "men-at-arms".



ITALIAN "HOUNSKULL" BASINET